

Two perspectives to assess the morality of a social practice: (126)

**Interactional approach:**

Focus on the individual's experience in the social practice

Assesses in terms of violations of duties not to harm the individual

**Structural approach:**

Focus on the collective's experience in the social practice

Assesses unjust distribution of power, knowledge, resources and their effects

The harm might not be significant to any single individual, but taken as a group, the harm is significant

**Benn and Lazar's thesis:**

While the interactional approach can discover moral wrongs, the criticism of automated influence is more compelling when one adopts a structural approach

In other words, Benn and Lazar will aim to show that automated influence leads to an unjust distribution of knowledge, resources, and/or power that promote invasions of privacy, exploitation, and manipulation

## **Automated Influence = (127)**

“The use of Artificial Intelligence to collect, integrate and analyse people’s data, and to deliver targeted interventions based on this analysis, intended to shape their behaviour for exogenous or endogenous ends”

e.g., advertising, recommender systems, newsfeed and search algorithms

## **Targeting: (127)**

- Matching people with products, services and content they may find appealing
- Tailoring the message to the individual based on their inferred susceptibility to that method of persuasion

⇒ Examples?

⇒ Do Benn and Lazar think targeting by automated influence is always morally wrong?

## **Manipulation (139):**

“Undermining an individual’s decision-making power... in order to change their behaviour”

- Undermines the individual’s autonomy
- Manipulator treats the manipulated as a subordinate

**Question:** Is Automated Influence *manipulative*?

## **Tailoring the message: (139)**

Manipulative if it targets weaknesses in the individual’s rational decision-making

- Objection: Is this any different from any other kind of advertising?
- Manipulative if it involves concealing facts that would undercut the message

## **Targeting the product: (140)**

Morally problematic if targets health conditions that are disclosed in social media

Possibly manipulative if the user would not consent were the methods of identifying the user as a target were disclosed

## Manipulation: **Interactional Approach** (140)

### Recommender algorithms

- Shape our options
- Influence our beliefs and desires
- Hold our attention for longer
- Direct our attention to services, products, content

**Question:** Is this manipulative?

Comparison to video games

**Question:** Is this morally harmful?

Need to show:

- (a) The manipulative is generally successful; and
- (b) The option chosen from manipulation is worse than the unmanipulated individual would have chosen

Benn and Lazar consider effects on behavior: (141)

- Advertising to promote one product over another
- Bigger products, like unsecured loans and job opportunities
- Political campaigning

Benn and Lazar consider effects on beliefs and desires: (141)

- Morally troubling
- But making the case is more persuasive when looking not at individual interactions, but group interactions

Manipulation: **Structural Approach** (141)

**Stochastic Manipulation:** a low probability of change to any one individual's behavior, but a higher probability of change to the group's behavior

Preys on: (142)

- Failure to coordinate our actions
- Propensity to Tragedy of the Commons

Harmful Effects on Beliefs and Desires:

New techniques enable small groups of people (tech companies) to exercise great power over groups and populations

Stochastic manipulation “pollutes our capacity for, and willingness to commit to, collective deliberation and action” (143)

Stochastic manipulation, even if not actually effective, is perceived to be effective, which undermines trust

## **Manipulation: Solution?**

Not simply removing harmful content

But ensuring that people have access to information that is important for them to know (whether they want it or not)

Need a way to redistribute resources, knowledge, and power  
Who is able to do that?